Enabling Tourism Marketing & SME Competitiveness.

Institutional Capacity Workshop · ITC YEP · Banjul · May 2026

WELCOME

Your trainer today

Alex Jeffries · Tourism & Digital Marketing Specialist

- **[Bio point 1]**

  e.g. years of experience in the sector

- **[Bio point 2]**

  e.g. geographic or sector focus

- **[Bio point 3]**

  e.g. what you bring to this workshop

- **EU YEP · The Gambia**

  Tourism and Creative Industries Project



Why we're here together

Where SMEs built enterprise capacity Monday to Wednesday, the next two days build system capacity.

From doing to enabling

Institutions don't market The Gambia — they make it possible for hundreds of others to do so well

Evidence-based

We'll look at real data on how The Gambia is seen, sold and reviewed by international markets

Practical

Simple, low-cost routines institutions can adopt within existing mandates and capacity

Participant-led

Space for reflection and exchange, ending in commitments you own and can sustain



The arc of the two days

Three movements — from positioning to system to commitments.

THURSDAY

Positioning & landscape

1

Where The Gambia stands, brand coordination, reading data, supporting SMEs

FRIDAY MORNING

Ecosystem & routines

2

Digital ecosystem, institutional visibility, a simple monitoring routine

FRIDAY AFTERNOON

Priorities & commitments

3

Concrete actions, coordination mechanisms, shared next steps

How this connects to the SME week

SMEs built enterprise capacity Mon–Wed. Institutions build system capacity Thu–Fri.

Monday — Know Your Customer

SMEs mapped their ideal visitor and drafted their unique value proposition

Tuesday — Build Your Brand

SMEs shaped brand identity — values, tone of voice, visual choices for their business

Wednesday — Go Digital

SMEs took brand online — content, platforms, day-to-day digital practice

Thu–Fri — Our turn

How institutions enable, coordinate and scale what SMEs are now doing

IMAGE PLACEHOLDER

Suggested: SME training room shot from earlier in the week, if available

SESSION 1

Where Does The Gambia Stand Today?

A shared reading of how the country is seen, sold and reviewed by international markets.

A shared reading of evidence

Not a critique of what's been done — a starting point for conversation, not a conclusion.

Purpose

Look at what the data shows about how The Gambia is seen from the outside

Tone

Findings are an external view — a complement to internal strategy, not a contradiction

What findings are

A shared reading of evidence and a starting point for institutional conversation

What they aren't

Not a critique, not a conclusion, not a judgment on existing institutional strategy



EXERCISE

01

Three Words Perception Gap

⏱ 15 MIN

WHAT YOU'LL DO

1 **Three words visitors use today**

Write three words you believe international visitors actually use to describe The Gambia today. (3 min)

2 **Three words you want them to use**

Write three words you would want international visitors to use to describe The Gambia. (3 min)

3 **Share in pairs**

Swap with your neighbour. Where is the gap widest? Where do you agree? (5 min)

4 **Back to the room**

Facilitator captures recurring words on the board. We'll return to these after the data. (4 min)

HOW INTERNATIONAL OPERATORS FRAME THE GAMBIA

95% · 91% · 9%

beach / resort · wildlife / nature · creative industries

SHARE OF INTERNATIONAL TOUR OPERATOR PAGES · DELIVERABLE 2, §3.2

Two narratives dominate — one is absent

How international tour operators frame The Gambia today, by share of operator pages.

95%

Beach & resort

The dominant framing in almost every operator package

91%

Wildlife & nature

Birding and river excursions as the second pillar

74%

Cultural heritage

Mentioned, but rarely as a primary reason to visit

9%

Creative industries

Festivals, crafts, music, performing arts — largely absent

16.9

The Gambia's Creative Tourism Score.

Regional mean: 30.9 · Senegal: 26% · Ghana: 21% · Gambia: 9%

CREATIVE TOURISM SCORE, OUT OF 100 · DELIVERABLE 2, TABLE 10

This reflects communication, not the offer

The 9% is about how The Gambia is being sold — not what it has to offer.

The product exists

Festivals, crafts, heritage, music and performing arts are real and already being delivered

The channels don't carry it

Operator pages, OTAs and tourism platforms don't yet carry this story to international buyers

Language access is limited

French and other key languages are largely absent from content reaching source markets

Fixable

A communicative problem is easier to change than a structural one — and institutions can help



Who is coming — and from where

Share of identifiable TripAdvisor reviews by source market · Deliverable 2, §4.4

45% UK / Anglophone	**34%** Dutch / Belgian
15% Francophone	**3%** German / Swiss
3% Southern European	**—** Other / unidentified

What each segment values

Average rating and one-line characterisation by source market. Francophone is the open gap.

4.06

Francophone

Only 15% of reviews despite proximity — held back by near-total absence of French content

4.32

UK / Anglophone

45% of reviews — the established core market, familiar with the destination

4.56

Dutch / Belgian

34% of reviews, highest rating of any group — seek immersive cultural experiences

6%

German + Southern EU

Germans / Swiss for wildlife; Spanish / Italian drawn by artistic quality

“

Liked —
but not looked for.

— DELIVERABLE 2, EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

#1

Regionally on safety.

A competitive advantage rarely foregrounded.

STRONGEST SENTIMENT THEME VS REGIONAL PEERS · DELIVERABLE 2, §4.2

Where The Gambia sits regionally

4th of 6 on creative industries digital maturity. The pattern is uneven.

STRONGEST

Marketing & Publishing · 38/70

Gambia's best-performing sub-sector — its digital capacity for storytelling is above the regional mean.

WEAKEST

Fashion & Design · 14/70

Lowest-scoring sub-sector — both product visibility and digital channels are underdeveloped.

16.9 → 33.9

Creative Tourism Score doubles when Gambia is packaged with Senegal.

PURE GAMBIA VS SENEGAL+GAMBIA TOURS · DELIVERABLE 2, TABLE 11

Three threads to carry forward

What institutions can hold on to from this session, before we turn to coordination.

Communicative, not structural

The gap is in how The Gambia is told, not what it has to offer

Francophone is the open gap

The biggest source-market opportunity is language access and French-language content

Regional framing unlocks

Packaging with Senegal more than doubles creative tourism visibility — a pattern to build on

Next — the institutional role

Session 2: how institutions coordinate the narrative without flattening sector diversity



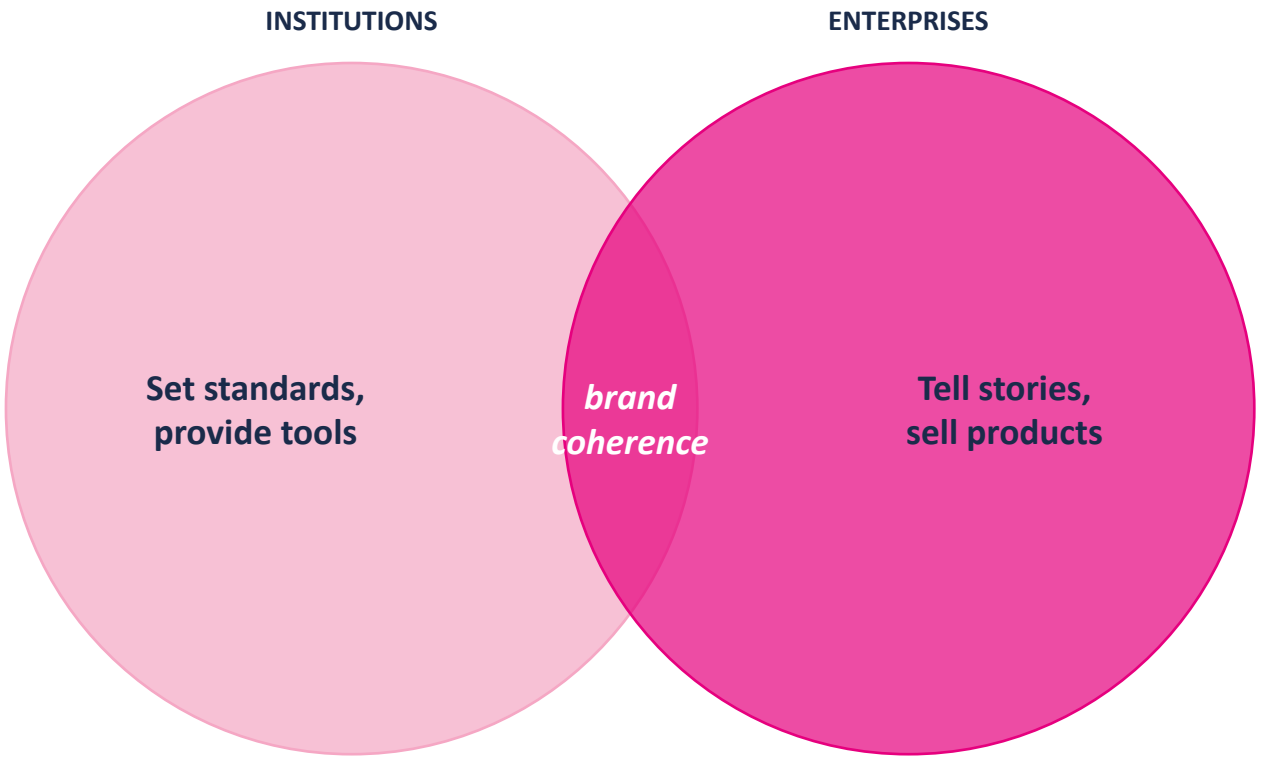
SESSION 2

The Institutional Role

Not the marketer of The Gambia — the enabler of marketing done by hundreds of others.

Not the marketer — the enabler

Destination brand coherence lives where institutions and enterprises meet.



Institutions without enterprises is policy. Enterprises without institutions is fragmentation.

Three institutional roles

What institutions do that SMEs, on their own, cannot.

STANDARDS

Setting standards

1

What should Gambian tourism look and feel like?

TOOLS

Providing tools

2

What do SMEs need to communicate well?

COORDINATION

Coordinating narratives

3

How do we avoid conflicting messages?

SESSION 2 · CASE STUDIES

How other destinations do it

Three regional examples — illustrative, not prescriptive.

CASE STUDY

Cape Verde · Small but visible

Strong international identity with limited infrastructure investment.

Voice

Consistent editorial tone across a small number of platforms

Language

Multilingual access built in from the start — English, Portuguese, French

Identity

Music and cultural identity sustained as continuous international presence

IMAGE PLACEHOLDER

Cape Verde official tourism
(suggested: festival / music scene)

"Small, coherent, unmistakable"

CASE STUDY

Senegal · Strong institutions, uneven diffusion

High institutional capability — but the private sector lags behind.

Anchors

Museum of Black Civilizations and major festivals carry the institutional weight

Gap

Smaller enterprises remain sporadic online — coordination has not yet reached them

Lesson

Institutional strength is necessary but not sufficient — diffusion to SMEs is a distinct challenge

IMAGE PLACEHOLDER

Museum of Black Civilizations
(suggested: Dakar cultural scene)

"Strong at the top, thin at the edges"

CASE STUDY

Ghana · Diaspora as distribution

Reaching international markets through community rather than advertising.

Channel

Diaspora audiences carry Ghanaian cultural content into international markets

Example

Global Mamas blends fair-trade credibility with process-led storytelling

Result

International e-commerce reach without a large marketing budget

IMAGE PLACEHOLDER

Global Mamas, Ghana
(suggested: craft production scene)

“Community as the marketing channel”

What these three have in common

Shared signal, specific identity — the pattern across Cape Verde, Senegal and Ghana.

A shared signal

Each destination has a recognisable, consistent voice carrying the whole offer

Specific identities

Sub-sectors — festivals, crafts, museums, music — retain their distinct stories

Low cost, high signal

Achieved through consistency and coordination, not through massive marketing spend

Institutions as enablers

Behind each example: an institutional actor holding the coherence together

IMAGE PLACEHOLDER

Suggested: Gambian artisan or festival scene — distinct yet Gambian

Managing sector diversity

Each sub-sector has its own audience and story. The institutional question: what unites them?

F

Festivals

Seasonal, time-bound, event-led · drives press and short-stay bookings

C

Crafts

Process, provenance, maker · travels beyond the visit as objects and stories

H

Heritage

Sites, memory, lineage · needs interpretation to land with international visitors

M

Music

Mobile, viral, borderless · the fastest-carrying Gambian cultural content

“

Show the process.
Stay coherent. Make it easy to buy.

— DELIVERABLE 2, CROSS-SECTOR SYNTHESIS

“Made in Gambia” — a framing, not a mandate

Artisan-certification logic applied to destination — a way of thinking, not a new label.

Origin

Every product and experience carries a shared signal of Gambian origin

Specificity

The shared signal does not replace the individual story — both travel together

Quality

Coherence becomes a proxy for trust — international buyers read it quickly

A way of thinking

Not a logo or certification scheme — a shared discipline about how things show up



Tools institutions can build

Concrete resources SMEs can adapt rather than build from scratch.

01

Photography library

Shared image/video archive SMEs can draw from — the highest-impact, lowest-effort tool

02

Messaging frameworks

Key phrases, positioning statements, tone guidelines in English and French

03

Brand toolkits

Colours, fonts, layout templates for social posts, flyers, signage — plug-and-play

04

Content calendars

Shared timeline of festivals, seasons, source-market planning windows

On the World Bank branding work

National brand identity work is underway. This session is not about defining or replacing it.

What this session is

Operational coordination at the sector level — how institutions help SMEs communicate well

What this session is not

Not a destination brand definition, not a logo exercise, not a rival process

How they fit together

Whatever the national brand turns out to be, institutions have a role in making it land across the sector

Framing for today

Focus on coordination and enablement — the work that makes any brand work in practice

IMAGE PLACEHOLDER

Suggested: neutral institutional or GT Board context — respectful tone

EXERCISE

02

Institutional Touchpoint Map

⏱️ 15 MIN

WHAT YOU'LL DO

1

List your touchpoints

List the ways your institution currently supports, interacts with, or communicates with tourism SMEs. (5 min)

2

Pair-share

Compare lists with a colleague from another institution. Where do you overlap? (4 min)

3

Spot the gaps

What kinds of SME needs does nobody in the room currently address? (3 min)

4

Map to the board

Facilitator captures overlaps, gaps and coordination opportunities on a shared board. (3 min)

Morning reflection

20 minutes, open discussion — before we break for lunch.

Q1 · Resonance

What from the last two sessions resonates with work already underway in your institution?

Q2 · Challenge

What feels most challenging — from an institutional perspective, not a personal one?

Q3 · Questions

What questions do you want to carry into the afternoon sessions on data and SME support?

Format

Open discussion — facilitator prompts, everyone speaks at least once if possible



LUNCH

See you at 13:30.

Afternoon picks up with data, landscape reading, and supporting SMEs.

SESSION 3

Data, Intelligence, and What It Tells You

Reading the landscape as a habit — not as a one-off research exercise.

Why most institutions don't use data systematically

Most decisions are made on anecdote, relationship, and instinct — and for understandable reasons.

- **Time**

  Data collection feels like it needs specialist skills and dedicated hours no one has

- **Cost**

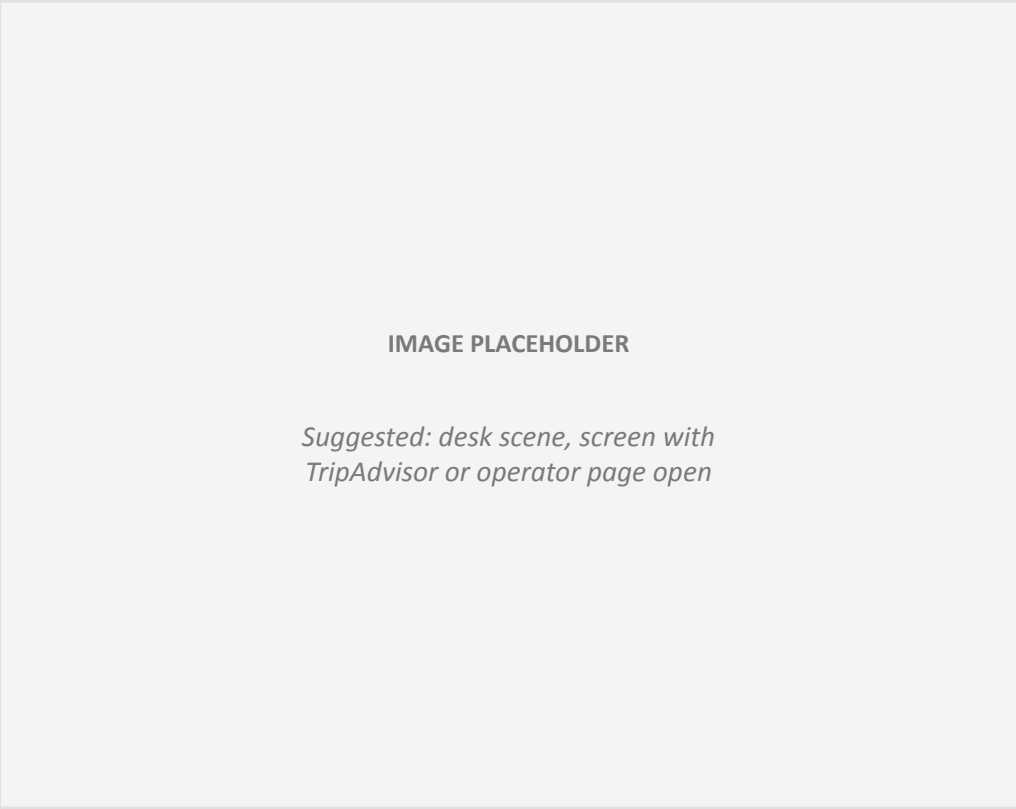
  Commissioned studies feel like the only way — but they're expensive and occasional

- **Habit**

  Instinct and relationships served well enough yesterday — why change today?

- **But —**

  Instinct creates blind spots — and a surprising amount of useful data is free and in the open



Three questions data answers that instinct can't

The case for data isn't sophistication — it's asking whether what we think is happening actually is.

APPEARANCE

How you appear

1

To people who have never heard of you

COMPARISON

How you compare

2

To places competing for the same visitors

TRAJECTORY

Whether you're improving

3

Or declining — over months and years, not feelings

SESSION 3 · FOUR TYPES OF INTELLIGENCE

What's already available — for free

Four types of intelligence you can read at the destination level without commissioning a study.

Who is coming, from where, and why

Source markets, motivations and ratings — the same five clusters we saw this morning.

What it tells you

Which markets are active, which aren't, and what different groups actually value

Where to look

TripAdvisor reviewer origins, arrivals data, operator client lists, airline market reports

Gambia today

UK / Anglophone 45%, Dutch / Belgian 34%, Francophone 15%, German / Swiss 3%, Southern EU 3%

Source

Deliverable 2, §4.4 — five clusters built from 5,682 identifiable reviews



How visible the destination is online

Six dimensions institutions can audit — for themselves and for key stakeholders.

What it tells you

Whether The Gambia appears — and how — in the places people search before they travel

The six dimensions

Social presence · website · visual content · discoverability · booking · platform integration

Gambia today

4th of 6 regionally on creative industries digital maturity — strongest in publishing, weakest in fashion

Source

Deliverable 2, §2.1 — same framework institutions can use to audit their own presence



What visitors say after they've been

Often different from what marketing promises — and more useful as a result.

What it tells you

Real visitor experience — what works, what frustrates, what surprises — themed by nationality

Where to look

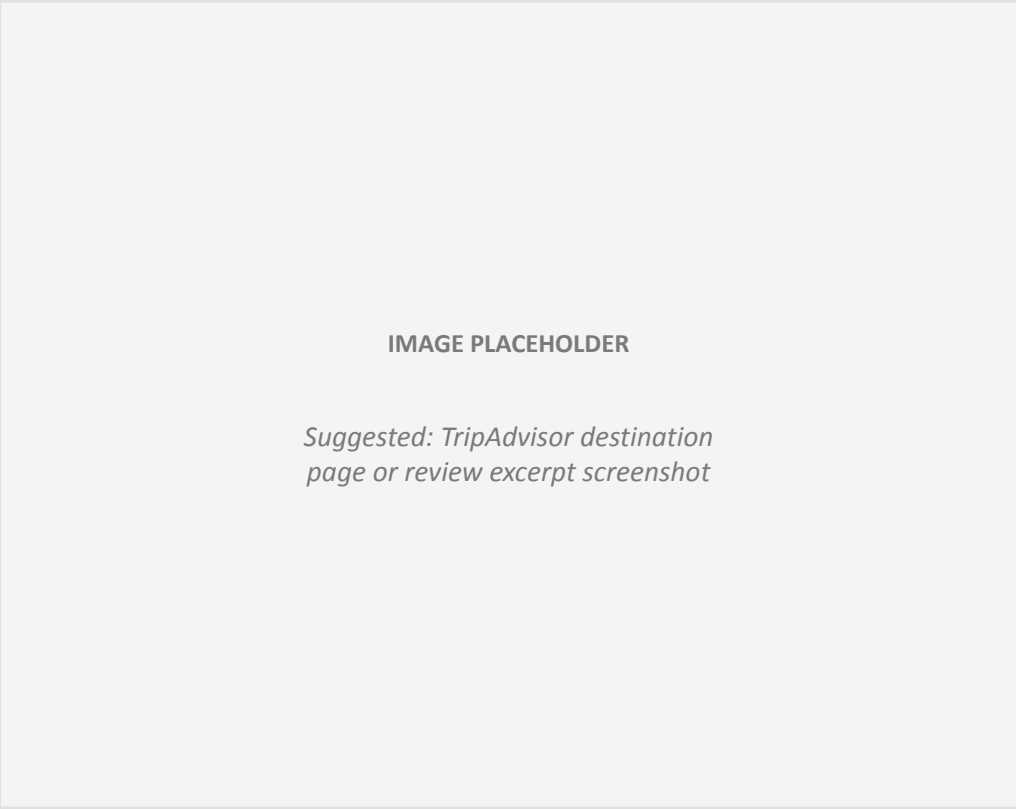
TripAdvisor, Google reviews, Booking.com comments, social media tags

Gambia today

Strongest on safety and artistic quality regionally · weakest on facilities and educational value

Source

Deliverable 2, §4 — 5,682 TripAdvisor reviews analysed across six West African destinations



How The Gambia is being sold

The single most influential factor in where international visitors choose to go.

What it tells you

How the country is packaged, which experiences are featured, which are absent

Where to look

Operator websites, OTA listings, package brochures — all publicly accessible

Gambia today

81% of pure Gambia tours score under 20/100 on creative tourism content

Source

Deliverable 2, §3 — 239 tour pages from 32 operators across 13 source markets



81%

Of pure Gambia tours score below 20/100 on creative.

The Gambia is sold almost exclusively as a beach and wildlife destination.

239 TOUR PAGES · 32 OPERATORS · 13 MARKETS · DELIVERABLE 2, §3

SESSION 3 · METHODOLOGY

How we did it

Not to teach research skills — to show what questions were asked, and what was freely available to answer them.

The questions we asked

Three questions institutions can ask of their destination, regularly.

VISIBILITY

How visible are we?

1

Compared to regional peers, across key channels

FRAMING

How do operators sell us?

2

Which stories and experiences reach international buyers

EXPERIENCE

What do visitors say?

3

Recurring themes, differences by nationality, trends over time

Publicly available sources

Everything you've seen today came from these four kinds of source. Nothing proprietary.

01

Operator websites

239 tour pages read directly — no login, no paywall, no data request

02

TripAdvisor

5,682 reviews across six destinations — public by design, searchable by country

03

Google Business

Hours, addresses, photos, ratings — shows what travellers see before arriving

04

Social channels

Public Instagram, Facebook, YouTube posts — volume, tone, engagement patterns

What this means for institutions

This kind of reading is possible without commissioning a study.

What it takes

Time, a clear set of questions, and a systematic approach — all things institutions can build in

What it doesn't take

Specialist staff, new budget lines, proprietary subscriptions or dedicated consultants

How often

Quarterly or monthly — routine beats sophistication every time

The shift

From one-off commissioned studies to institutional habit of landscape reading

IMAGE PLACEHOLDER

Suggested: institutional staff in office — focused, everyday work

SESSION 3 · FREE TOOLS

Four tools you can use Monday morning

No budget. No training. Just a browser and a quiet half hour each week.

Four tools to start with

Each free, each public, each usable by a single person with no special training.

01

Operator spot-checks

Visit 5-10 operator sites quarterly — note how The Gambia is described, what's featured, what's missing

02

Google Trends

Track search interest in "Gambia" over time and by country. Compare with Senegal or Cape Verde. No account needed

03

TripAdvisor

Read 20 most recent reviews monthly. Note recurring themes, flag anything concerning, track ratings over time

04

Google Alerts

Set alerts for "Gambia tourism" or "Gambia travel" — get new coverage delivered by email as it appears

The dashboard approach

Six to eight indicators, tracked quarterly, shared across institutions. The value is consistency, not sophistication.

A starter set

ITO visibility · average sentiment score · verified review volume · average rating

Baseline → 2026 target

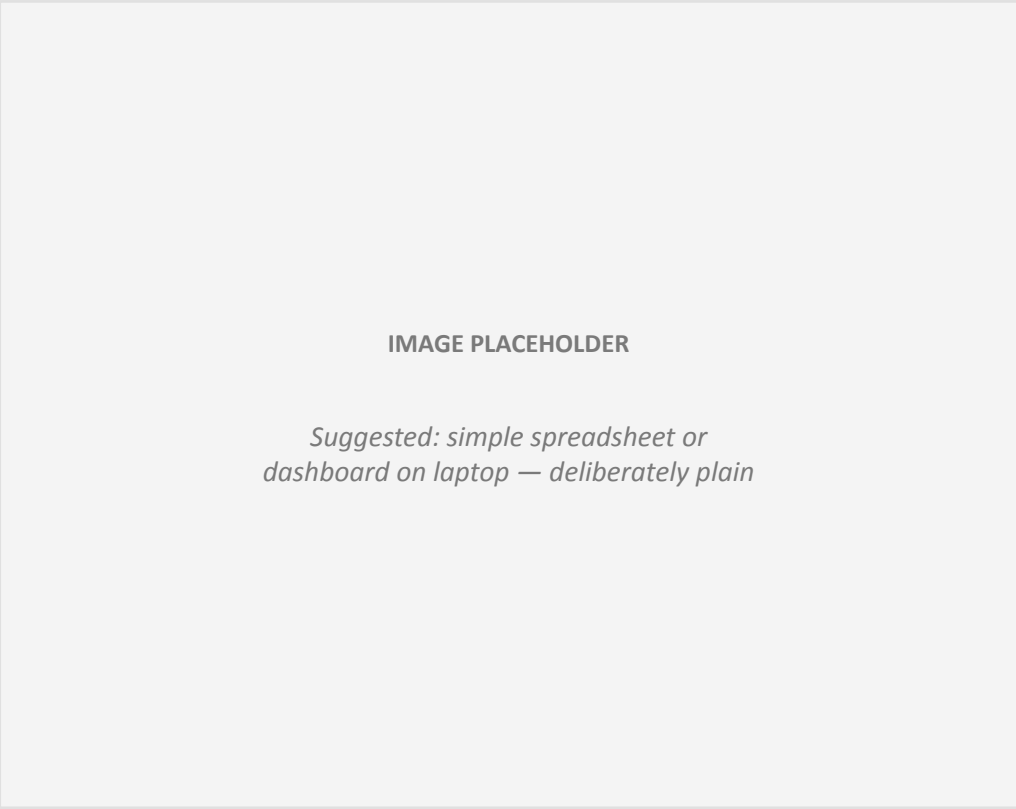
ITO visibility 52% → 60% · sentiment +0.24 → +0.30 · reviews +25% · rating 4.06 → 4.20

Frequency

Collected quarterly — same spreadsheet, same questions, same person each time

Sharing

One-page briefing each quarter — to other institutions, to SMEs, to the GT Board



EXERCISE

03

Live Walkthrough

⏱ 15 MIN

WHAT YOU'LL DO

1 Open a real operator page

Facilitator projects a live Gambia tour page. What creative content is there? What's missing? (5 min)

2 Read recent reviews together

Open Gambia's TripAdvisor destination page. Read two or three recent reviews out loud. (5 min)

3 One question each

If you were reading this monthly in your institution, what would you act on? (3 min)

4 Fallback if offline

If internet fails, use pre-printed one-page extracts of operator pages and reviews. Same outcome. (2 min)

Two or three things you can check next month

Not a new tool, not a new budget, not a new staff line — just a habit of landscape reading.

The habit

Look regularly at how others see The Gambia — not technical sophistication, just consistency

The sources

Everything you need is free and public — operator sites, TripAdvisor, Google tools, social

The routine

Pick two or three indicators you can actually check next month — then actually check them

Next — supporting SMEs

Session 4: how institutions translate what they're reading into support for Gambian SMEs



SESSION 4

From Training to Sustainable Market Access

What institutions can do that training alone cannot.

Training is not enough

Knowledge builds capability — but capability alone does not create market access.

The gap

Between 'can do' and 'does' is where most SMEs get stuck — and where institutions have the most important role.

Visibility

Being findable by the right audiences — something most SMEs cannot achieve alone.

Credibility

Being trusted by buyers and platforms — a signal that requires infrastructure, not just effort.

Connectivity

Being linked to the distribution channels where international travelers make decisions.



Three things SMEs need beyond training

Institutions are uniquely positioned to provide or broker all three.

VISIBILITY

Be found

1

Discoverable by the right international audiences

CREDIBILITY

Be trusted

2

Recognised by buyers, platforms, and review channels

CONNECTIVITY

Be linked in

3

Integrated into the distribution channels that drive bookings

Institutions are uniquely positioned

Not by doing it for SMEs — by creating the conditions that make it possible.

Relationships

Institutions have credibility and connections with operators, platforms, and buyers that individual SMEs do not.

Leverage

Negotiating destination-level agreements with OTAs and platforms that would be out of reach for a single business.

Mandate

The institutional role is to enable — setting standards, providing tools, and coordinating narratives across the sector.

Scale

A shared photography library or messaging toolkit, built once, is available to hundreds of SMEs simultaneously.



Five visitor personas — five sets of digital needs

Each persona has specific needs SMEs struggle to meet alone. Source: Deliverable 2, §5

01

Market Explorer

Needs: bookable craft experiences with clear provenance and pricing

02

Heritage Seeker

Needs: structured heritage itineraries with cultural context in English

03

Learning Traveler

Needs: educational framing — workshops, demonstrations, storytelling

04

Dutch Immersive Explorer

Needs: multi-day immersive programmes, local contacts, and booking confidence

What exists — and what's missing

Many gaps are coordination failures rather than genuine absences of support.

Trade fair access

CURRENTLY EXISTS — some participation support available for key sector events.

Periodic training

CURRENTLY EXISTS — training cycles, though often one-off rather than ongoing.

Ongoing coaching

MISSING — no sustained mentoring or follow-up after formal training ends.

Content production support

MISSING — no shared photo/video library, no shared messaging frameworks.



Often coordination, not absence

The most valuable contribution is often not a new service — it's reducing friction in reaching what already exists.

What institutions can do now

Map existing services across all institutions. Identify where SMEs fall through gaps between them.

Reduce friction

Make it easier to find, apply for, and use support that is already available — a directory, a contact, a warm referral.

Coordinate referrals

When one institution cannot help, the answer should not be silence. Warm introductions to the right institution have high impact at near-zero cost.

Avoid duplication

Shared awareness of what each institution offers prevents SMEs from being sent in circles and prevents institutions from duplicating effort.



SESSION 4

Three Practical Approaches

Coaching · Brokering Access · Content Support

① Coaching & mentoring infrastructure

The most sustainable support structures are those that outlast the project cycle.

The problem

Formal training builds skills, but knowledge decays without application and follow-up. SMEs need accompaniment, not just instruction.

The approach

Build a pool of trained mentors who provide ongoing, contextualised coaching after training ends — sector-specific and practical.

Why it works

Peer coaching is low-cost, high-trust, and more relevant than repeat classroom cycles. The mentor network itself becomes a sector asset.

What institutions do

Identify, recruit, train, and coordinate the mentor pool. Provide the structure; the mentors provide the content.



② Brokering access to platforms & buyers

High-value, relatively low-cost — institutions have leverage individual SMEs simply do not.

OTAs & platforms

Negotiate destination-level agreements with Booking.com, TripAdvisor Experiences, GetYourGuide — opening doors SMEs cannot reach alone.

International operators

Organise familiarisation trips so operators experience Gambian creative products firsthand — the most direct route into operator portfolios.

Media & press

Facilitate visits by travel journalists and content creators reaching international audiences. Institutions identify, invite and host.

Trade fairs

Support SME participation in World Travel Market and sector trade events — preparation, materials, and follow-up introductions.



③ Content & visibility support

A shared content library reduces duplication and raises quality across the whole sector.

The lever

Commission professional photography and video of artisans, festivals, and heritage sites. Make the library available to all SMEs and operators.

The evidence

Deliverable 2, Table 18 (Digital Lever 3): 'Authentic Gambia' visual brand campaign — estimated impact: HIGH · estimated effort: LOW.

What to build

Shared photo and video archive, English and French messaging frameworks, brand toolkits, and a shared content calendar aligned to the festival cycle.

What SMEs do with it

Adapt, not build from scratch. Consistent imagery and tone, professional quality, accessible across social media and operator platforms.



From one-off intervention to sustainable support

Café Monts Nimba — same product, transformed perception.

ONE-OFF

PROJECT MODEL

Intensive during project cycle. Then funding ends. Then silence. Skills decay without practice.

SUSTAINABLE

INSTITUTIONAL MODEL

Support embedded in institutional mandate. Peer networks carry each other. Simple enough to maintain.

EXERCISE

04

One Thing in Six Months

⏱️ 15 MIN

WHAT YOU'LL DO

1

In pairs

What is one thing your institution could do in the next six months to better support SME visibility or market access — without additional budget? (7 min)

2

Share back

Each pair shares their answer. Facilitator captures themes on the board. (5 min)

3

Group by type

Facilitator groups responses: access / content / coaching / coordination. (2 min)

4

Reflection

What is most realistic? Where could two institutions work together? (1 min)

Afternoon reflection

20 minutes, open discussion — grounding the session in the week's actual experience.

Q1 · Existing strengths

What support structures already exist that could be strengthened with relatively little effort?

Q2 · Critical gaps

Where are the most critical gaps — the things that, if addressed, would make the biggest difference to SME performance?

Q3 · Coordination

What is the one coordination action that would require institutions to work together rather than separately?

Format

Open discussion — grounded in what participants observed about SMEs they met this week.



Three threads from today

Carry these into Friday's sessions on digital ecosystem, monitoring, and commitments.

Communicative, not structural

The gap between what The Gambia offers and how it is seen internationally is a storytelling and channel problem — institutions can help fix it.

Enablers, not marketers

The institutional role is to set standards, provide tools, and coordinate narratives — making it easier for SMEs to communicate well.

Routine beats sophistication

A simple check done consistently every month is worth more than a complex analysis done once. Data habits matter more than data budgets.

See you Friday

Tomorrow: digital ecosystem, institutional visibility, and building a simple monitoring routine — then priorities and commitments.



Day 1 complete.
See you tomorrow.

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